

Research Protocol

Intergenerational Goal Continuity and Social Evolution Theory

Document ID	ASU-IGC-001-PROTOCOL
Owner	Toby William Duffield
Version	1.0
Issue date	18 September 2026
Classification	Public method / controlled master
Review status	External review pending
Related publication	https://asultd.com/
Status boundary: This protocol defines how the theory should be investigated. It is not evidence that the theory is correct, does not report a completed systematic review and is not a claim of peer review or institutional endorsement.	

Document control

Purpose

To convert a developing theoretical framework into an auditable research programme with stable terminology, numbered propositions, explicit alternatives, evidence thresholds, disconfirmation criteria, ethical boundaries and revision controls.

Scope

- Family and social transmission of priorities, narratives, practices and expectations.
- Moderating social, institutional, economic, historical and informational conditions.
- Disruption, rejection and redirection of continuity.
- The near-term cultural and behavioural effects of AI-rich environments.
- A separately labelled speculative annex for possible long-term biological questions.

Status taxonomy

Status	Meaning
Established evidence domain	A wider field with identifiable evidence; not proof of the ASU model.
Supported interpretation	A reasoned reading consistent with evidence but open to alternatives.
Working hypothesis	A proposition intended for testing and possible rejection.
Speculative hypothesis	A low-confidence, long-range possibility not established by current evidence.
Open research question	A defined issue without a predetermined conclusion.

Core terminology

Term	Working definition
Goal continuity	Recurring direction or priority across time; not a single conscious family objective.
Transmission	Learning, modelling, expectation, narrative, resource, network or institutional pathways.
Pressure	A persistent condition that changes incentives, attention, exposure, constraint or perceived risk.
Adaptation	A behavioural, cognitive, cultural or institutional response; not automatically biological evolution.
Interruption	A material weakening, redirection or ending of an earlier pattern.

Numbered propositions

ID	Proposition	Disconfirming or weakening evidence
P01	Recurring family narratives, expectations and practices may influence later priorities through learning and socialisation.	No association after credible controls, or better explanation by unrelated factors.
P02	Social, institutional, economic and historical conditions may moderate whether continuity strengthens, changes or ends.	No meaningful moderation across well-designed comparative studies.
P03	Separation, rejection, mobility, new relationships and institutional change may redirect or interrupt continuity.	Predicted disruptions do not alter measured outcomes.
P04	AI-rich environments may change which cognitive skills are practised, delegated, rewarded or neglected.	Longitudinal evidence shows no relevant change or effects are better explained elsewhere.
P05	Many interacting personal and group trajectories may contribute to changes in institutions, norms and collective priorities.	Individual-level mechanisms do not scale or aggregate as predicted.

Research questions

1. Which mechanisms transmit priorities or narratives across generations?
2. Under which conditions does continuity strengthen, fragment, change or end?
3. How much observed continuity remains after socioeconomic, institutional and genetic confounding are addressed?
4. Which AI-related changes persist beyond novelty, education and workplace design effects?
5. Can individual-level mechanisms be linked credibly to group or institutional outcomes?

Competing explanations

- General social learning and cultural evolution
- Developmental psychology and family systems
- Socioeconomic persistence and institutional effects
- Behavioural genetics and gene–environment correlation
- Selection, reporting, memory and survivorship bias
- Chance, individual agency and within-family variation

Evidence and review method

Evidence thresholds

Control	Minimum expectation
Claim fit	The source must address the narrow claim, population and mechanism attributed to it.
Source quality	Prefer systematic reviews, peer-reviewed primary research, official statistics and primary law or policy where appropriate.
Causal restraint	Association must not be restated as causation, heredity, intention or biological evolution.
Contrary evidence	Null, negative and credible alternative findings must be logged and assessed.
Triangulation	Stronger conclusions require convergence across methods, populations or data sources.
Revision	Propositions must be narrowed, changed or retired when evidence requires it.

Structured literature review

1. Fix the proposition, population, mechanism or exposure, comparator and outcome.
2. Record databases, search strings, dates, filters and supplementary searches.
3. Apply written inclusion and exclusion criteria and retain exclusion reasons.
4. Extract design, sample, measures, findings, uncertainty, limitations, funding and relevance.
5. Assess quality and exact claim fit without converting association into causation.
6. Synthesis must report convergence, inconsistency, uncertainty, gaps and alternatives.

Minimum evidence record

Source ID; proposition ID; citation; stable link or DOI; source type; research question; jurisdiction; population; design; sample; measures; main result; effect or uncertainty where reported; limitations; conflicts or funding; support/challenge/neutral classification; reviewer note; review date.

Evidence-to-claim decision

Decision	Rule
Support	The finding is materially consistent with the defined proposition and credible alternatives have been considered.
Challenge	The finding is inconsistent with the proposition or supports a materially better explanation.
Neutral	The source is relevant context but does not discriminate between the proposition and alternatives.
Insufficient	Method, sample, reporting or claim fit does not support a

Decision	Rule
	reliable directional judgement.

Ethics, governance and revision

Human research boundary

Research involving people or sensitive records requires an appropriate lawful basis, informed consent where applicable, data minimisation, privacy protection, safeguarding, secure retention and independent ethical review when required. This document does not itself authorise participant research.

AI extension

The near-term programme concerns cultural and behavioural change: skill practice, delegation, verification, judgement, dependence and institutional power. Long-term biological change is a speculative question requiring a much higher evidential threshold and is not inferred from short-term observations.

External review

Seek conceptual, methods, ethics, data-protection, legal and lived-experience review appropriate to the output. Informal contact, silence or private feedback must not be represented as endorsement. Publish review scope, date, permitted attribution, response and resulting revision where permission allows.

Revision control

Version	Date	Change	Approval
1.0	18 September 2026	Initial controlled research protocol	Owner issued

Review record

Reviewer / organisation	Scope	Date	Outcome / actions

Controlled-copy note: The editable master and research registers should be retained privately. Public copies should be exported as non-editable reference PDFs with the same document ID and version.